

the garden. The heat of the day had given way to cooler air, the moon was a week from being full and the creek flowed at a steady pace. We didn't talk as we ate. We were used to each other's company and it was a comfortable silence.

"Have you had a good birthday?" he asked me as we both had finished our cake.

"It has been amazing," I told him.

"I was afraid it would trigger too many bad memories," he said.

"It had its moments. But in the end, this birthday was much better and completely different." He nodded.

"How do you feel about the games?" he asked.

"About the games or about what will happen when we won't be playing?" I asked. He looked at me and smirked.

"The later," he said.

"I don't know. I'm nervous. I look forward to seeing my brother, but I'm scared he will be angry with me. With James... I just don't know what to think. I don't have feelings for him, those died a long time ago. And I think I mostly have forgiven him for what he did, it led me to end up here. But I'm afraid the bitterness will surface when I see him," I told him honestly.

"Would you prefer to stay home?" he asked.

"No." I didn't need to think about it. Despite my mixed feelings, I knew I would never skip the event. My pack needed me. "How about you? I'm not the only one with complicated family matters," I asked him. He grunted.

"I have dealt with them at the Alpha meetings. I'm predicting my brother will try to force a joining of the packs. Again."

"At least we will have each other," I told him. He gave me a smile.

"That is true." We sat a moment longer, thinking about what we had talked about. I felt better after sharing my fears with Finlay. I always did. "Ready for bed?" he asked. I nodded, and he stood up and reached his hands towards me. I took it and he helped me up. We stood on the porch in the moonlight and neither of us had let go. Our eyes met and after a couple of heartbeats during which none of us did anything, Finlay tugged lightly in my hand. The tug wasn't hard enough to do anything. But I found myself walking towards him until our toes almost touched. Our hands were still connected and the air was filled with the tension which usually was under the surface whenever we were close. Now it had been released and it was almost palatable. I don't know who made the first move, or if we made it together. One moment we stood looking at each other, the next moment we were kissing like it was the only way to survive. Finlay's free hand had moved to my cheek and he gently held my face as he kissed me. My free hand had landed on his waist, keeping me anchored with him. Finlay tugged on my lower lip and with a moan I opened my mouth to let his tongue inside. I had kissed other men, even if it was a long time ago, but nothing could have prepared me for this kiss. It set my body and soul on fire. Everything I held back for six years came flooding out. Finlay responded with a flood of his own. His hand moved into my hair and he gripped a handful of it. It didn't hurt, but it was a possessive gesture that had

me moaning for the second time. As if my moan had unlocked something in him, Finlay locked his arms around me and picked me up. Next thing I knew, I was inside Finlay's house, in the hallway he let me down and pressed me up against the wall. My hands had wrapped around his neck and one of my hands tangled in his blond hair and the other caressed over his shoulders. A growl escaped Finlay as he pulled my leg up to wrap around his waist. The skirt on the dress hiked up to expose the leg. Finlay's strong hand rubbed all over my naked leg and all I could do was roll my hips against him. This was new territory for me. Finlay grunted and moved his hips with mine. It almost sent me over the edge. His lips left mine as he kissed down my neck. Both my hands grabbed his hair in desperation. His hands had landed on my ass and were pulling me towards him in pace with me rolling my hips.

"Finlay," I moaned.

"Amie," he growled in response. I tried to ignore the voice in my head telling me I couldn't do this. I could, I needed to do this, I told the voice.

"Finlay," I whimpered. He froze as he heard the change in my voice. I hated myself. He tilted his head so his forehead rested on my shoulder. I could feel his heavy breaths against my skin and my hands were still tangled in his hair. "We can't do this, Finn," I told him in a whisper. I felt close to tears. He looked up at me and cupped my face with both his hands.

"Amie, I can't ignore this thing between us any longer. It's eating me up when I can't act on the instinct to show you affection, take your hand, put my arm around you, kiss you. Every day I have these instincts, my wolf pushes me to stake my claim to you," he told me. I caressed his face.

"I know. I feel it too." I told him.

"Then why can't we?"

"In four weeks we will go to the biggest meeting of wolves in the world. The chance of you meeting your mate there is high," I told him. For once I didn't hide how the thought pained me.

"Amie," he said, leaning his forehead against mine.

"No Finn. It is what it is."

"I will reject her. I don't want anyone else but you," he told me. There was so much certainty in his voice.

"If you did it would break me," I honestly said.

"Why?"

"Because it would be my fault someone would be rejected. How can I live with that?"

"Amie, love, it would be my decision. I love you and I can't see myself loving anyone else this way." His declaration of love had the first of my tears running over.

"I love you too. And it scares me how much. I'm terrified of what will happen when you meet your mate. If I give myself to you like I want to and I have to give

you up." I paused to collect myself. "I won't be able to pick up the pieces of myself after. It will be so much worse then when I was rejected."

"I would never do that to you," he insisted. I smiled at him through my tears.

"I know you wouldn't do it intentionally. But we both know that things happen when you meet your true mate. And if you do, I wouldn't want to stand in your way." Finlay kissed me. It wasn't full of fire this time. It was soft and gentle.

"Please don't cry, Red. You are breaking my heart," he said, wiping away my tears and kissing the skin where they had been. "I'm not getting younger. If I want a family I can't wait forever." he said. I chuckled.

"The games are four weeks away, Finn. I don't think your balls will shrivel up until then." He smiled and kissed my forehead.

"Probably not," he agreed.

"I will make you a deal," I told him.

"Like the one that let me lure you to the pack?"

"Something like it. We will hold off on this and focus on preparing for the games. If you don't find your mate during the games, we will revisit this when we get back home," I suggested. He looked at me.

"I have one condition," he said.

"And what is that?" I asked.

"When we are alone, we don't pretend this doesn't exist. I get to tell you I love you and I get to hold your hand and be close to you. As long as we don't cross any lines. And I get to make sure to keep other males away when we are at the games," he told me.

"I think that is more than one condition. But I will agree to it, as long as I can do the same, with the exception if you meet your mate," I said. He smiled.

"I give you permission to chase my mate away as well," he told me. He gave me a long kiss. "To keep me going for two months," he said. It would be a long two months, I thought.

"I should go," I told him. He didn't move, but kept me caged against the wall.

"Do you want to leave?" he asked.

"No. But I feel like it wouldn't be fair of me to stay. I may be inexperienced with these things. But I don't want to tease you," I told him.

"Inexperienced... Amie, have you ever...?" his question remained half unfinished. I blushed.

"No. I was eighteen when I was rejected. Remember? After that, I lived with humans and then I met you," I told him.

"Fuck. Maybe it was good that you stopped me. When we do this, it needs to be done right," he told me. I giggled.

"I trust you on that," I said.

“Stay. I don’t want you to leave. Not like this, not when we finally have got all of this out.” I looked at him and nodded. He stepped back and held out his hand. I took it and he led me to the couch. He sat down and pulled me into his lap. When he was sure I was comfortable, he put his feet up on the coffee table and leaned back. I felt him relax. I snuggled up in his arms and enjoyed the closeness, his body heat and the scent of forest which always surrounded him. “Go to sleep, Red. We will deal with everything when the sun is up,” he told me.

“Good night, Finn. Thank you for a perfect birthday.”

“Anything for you, love.” He kissed my hair, and I felt at peace.

Chapter 28



Finlay

After Amie's birthday, things changed between us. For the better if you ask me. The tension that had been smouldering under the surface had been released and it felt like a relief. Our deal had me frustrated at times, but it did give me a timeframe for when I would finally get what I had longed for. I understood her fear, she had been let down by someone she trusted, someone who would be the one person she should have been able to rely on. But I had no doubt how all of this would end. No matter what happened during the games, when we got back home I would make her my Luna. Now I knew she felt the same for me as I did for her and with that, I knew the future was with her. I had also stopped holding back when it came to social touching. When we interacted on a day to day basis I let myself place a hand on her shoulder, or place my hand on her back when we were walking. Amie did the same. I had seen the looks my aunt was giving us, the smile on her lips told me she approved.

It was almost a week after Amie's birthday and I had asked the top tiers to meet in our meeting room. It was time for us to choose who would go to the games. Amie

was already sitting in her chair when I arrived. I smiled and walked up to her. I bent down and placed a kiss on her cheek.

"Hello, beautiful," I told her. Her hand went up and caressed my neck.

"Hi there. Having a good day?" she asked, I heard her smile in her voice.

"I am," I told her and created a little space between us as I heard Sam and Medow come walking. I enjoyed our brief moments of intimacy. We took our seats at the table and Medow put Martina on the playmat we had set up. "Time to decide who will be going to the games," I told them and they all nodded. "We have five places to fill for the game and we are allowed another ten people for support staff. Let's make sure we get the best of the best. The floor is open."

"You and Amie are the obvious choices for participants in the game," Sam said and Medow nodded.

"As are you, Sam," Amie added.

"I don't know," Sam said and looked at Medow. We all knew Medow was not a top candidate for the games. She had a lot of good qualities and I knew we were lucky to have her in our top tier, but her strengths were not relevant to the games.

"Medow, it would be good to have you as part of our staff," I said. She smiled at me and then glanced down at her daughter.

"Thank you, Alpha. But I don't think I will join this year. Martina is too young. I don't want to bring her to a place with so many unknown wolves and I can't leave

her here for a month. But my mate will be going," she told us. Her reasoning was good, I thought.

"Baby," Sam objected.

"No, sweetie. You need to go. You have trained hard for this. You are the pack's best warrior and one of us needs to bring glory to the family name," she told him with a smile.

"But it's for a month. I will surely die being separated from you and the little one for that long," he complained.

"I think you will survive."

"Fine," Sam surrendered.

"Good," I said and put his name down.

"I'm thinking of Jake and Ramses as the final two for the game. Jake has worked hard, he is brilliant and he has even made progress on the physical parts. Ramses has been with us for a year and he is dedicated to the pack. His life as a lone wolf gives him a good rounded skill set," Amie said. I felt a brief pang of jealousy towards Ramses. He and Amie had a lot in common. But it went away just as quickly. I nodded. They were both good choices.

"Any other suggestions?" I asked. There were none and I was happy with the group we had put together. We turned our attention to the support staff. The games weren't just about the games, even if it was the focus. The games were spread out during four weeks. In between them there were council meetings, social

gatherings, panel discussions and time for packs to sit down and talk. It meant we needed a diverse group of pack members to take with us. Healers, in case of injuries, wolves that could feed us, we decided to bring the pack lawyer and two of our elders. I sent out mindlinks to the ones chosen who were not in the room. I asked them to come by the meeting room spread out over the day. We talked to all of them. Asked if they were willing and able to join us. To my relief no one turned us down. Then we talked about what we expected of them. By the end of the day it was only my aunt left. She walked into the room and smiled at us.

"What is this all about?" she asked.

"We want to ask you to come with us to the games, aunt," I told her.

"An old woman like me? I don't think I will be any good at climbing and jumping. Surely we have better wolves in the pack," she said. I was stunned to silence. Did she think I had offered her to take part in the games? Amie looked at me and laughed.

"Matilda, you know you can't tease him like that. He takes you too seriously to see the joke," she told my aunt and patted me on the shoulder. My aunt laughed, as did Sam and Medow. It looked like I had been the only one who hadn't caught onto her joke.

"Oh, right. Funny," I said. It made everyone laugh even harder.

"Why do you want me to come?" my aunt asked.

"We could use you both in your role as an elder and with you there we know we will have amazing food to keep us going," Amie answered.

“That is sweet of you. What about the pack, who will be looking after them?” my aunt asked.

“I will. I don’t want to bring Martina to the games. And Shelly can help me as well,” Meadow said.

“I could use you,” I told my aunt. She looked at me and her face turned serious. We both knew my brother was likely to try something. She nodded.

“Okay, you need someone to take care of you, I guess,” she said. “Let me know when we are leaving and I will be ready.”

“Thank you, aunt.”

“Dinner will be ready in twenty minutes, I expect to see you all there. That includes you, Alpha,” she said and walked out. We all chuckled.

“I think we have a stinker that needs to be changed,” Meadow said, scrunching her nose. She picked up Martina and headed for the bathroom, Sam trailing after her to make sure they were safe on the twenty feet walk. Amy stood up and walked to stand behind me. At first I was confused by what she was doing. Then her hands started kneading my shoulders and I let out a huff as I felt the muscles relaxing.

“Do you want to talk about it?” she asked. My brain was too focused on her hands for me to make sense of what she was asking.

“Huh?” I asked.

“Your brother,” she said, and I heard the smile she had in her voice.

“Not really. I don’t enjoy talking about him in general and I definitely don’t want to ruin a nice moment like this by thinking about him.” She hummed in the way I knew meant she wouldn’t press me, but she was filing it away to bring it up later. She continued to massage my shoulders and I tilted my head back to lean against her stomach. My eyes were closed and I enjoyed the moment. After a while she stopped and leaned down to place a kiss on my forehead.

“We need to get to dinner before your aunt comes and drags us to the table,” she told me. I sat up, took one of her hands off my shoulder and placed a kiss on it.

Chapter 29



Amie

"You need to spill it," Meadow said as she sat on my bed, feeding Martina as I was packing.

"Spill what?" I asked as I tried to figure out if I needed more than one dress.

"Oh no, you don't get to be all oblivious about this. As your friend I need to know what's going on between you and Finlay," she said.

"I don't know what you mean," I said. It sounded fake even in my own ears.

"Amie," she said in her best mom voice.

"Fine!" I paused and sat down on the bed as well. "So this thing happened on my birthday," I started.

"You slept together?!" she exclaimed.

"No! And keep your voice down. We're in a house full of werewolves with super hearing," I hissed.

"Sorry, sorry. I got a little excited. So what was this thing?"

"We kissed. Well, that is an understatement, but it's the word I'm going to use so I don't give you an aneurysm."

"Oh my, oh my. This is amazing. Finally!" she said. She almost bounced on the bed in excitement, but remembered Martina was eating and settled down. I gave her a short version of what had happened, carefully edited to keep the more spicy bits out. "So the two of you just decided to pause everything?" she asked when I was done.

"Kind of. I know it's not fair to him. But I'm petrified when I think that he might find his mate. I'm already way too deep. If I let myself think he is mine and he ends up being someone else's..." I let the rest hang in the air. Meadow gave me a sad smile.

"I get it. We wolves are lucky in the sense that we have mates. It makes it less scary to give our hearts away," she said.

"Yeah. Until your mate rejects you and the big, sexy Alpha both you and your wolf get hung up on hasn't found his. Then it just complicates things," I told her.

"Yeah, it does. But, I'm still happy for you. The two of you have been hovering around each other since the day you came here to visit. It's good for you to finally get it out and talk about it. And if it helps at all, it's easy to see how much he cares for you. I know you don't want him to reject his mate, and I get it. But I think he

would in a heartbeat. If I didn't know he would have swooped you up and claimed you a long time ago if it was true, I would say you were mates." I blushed.

"We aren't, but it's sweet of you to say," I told her. Martina gave up a satisfied burp and Medow placed her on the bed with a soft rattle to occupy her with. I tickled her tummy before getting up to get back to packing. "One dress should be enough, right?" I asked.

"No. You need at least three. One never knows," Medow told me. I scrunched my nose.

"Then I would need another bag," I told her. Medow giggled.

"Amie, you will be gone for four weeks. I think it's okay if you can't fit it all into one bag," she told me.

"How many is Sam bringing?" I asked as I took out another bag.

"I have no clue. By the amount of 'may be useful to have' things he keeps piling up. I would guess closer to twenty." I laughed.

"Okay. So two should be okay," I agreed.



Later in the afternoon we all gathered in the dining room. It was the day before leaving and everyone who would be going was sitting together. There were

conversations about what the next four weeks would bring going on all around me.

"Are you ready to leave in the morning?" Finlay asked me.

"Yes. Medow helped me pack earlier. How about you?"

"All done."

"Good. I talked to Matilda and she has made us some amazing food to eat during the drive. We still need to decide who rides with who. We need to make sure we have room for the luggage as well as all the people. But we want to use as few cars as we can," I told him.

"It's easy. I will take my truck, you will ride with me and we will take as much luggage as possible. Sam, Jake, Ramses and Aunt Matilda will go in Sam's car and they will have the food we need. Then our two healers, elder Jona and Mandy will go in one car with their personal belongings and the healing equipment. The rest will go in Robert's SUV," he told me.

"You and me in your truck? What about Beula?" I asked.

"Red, no one will voluntarily get into that car. And I'm not letting you drive there on your own. Besides, we can't bring that monstrosity and let the other packs see it," he told me.

"Hey! She is a workhorse. She has been good to me for ten years. She is amazing," I objected.

“Sure, sure. And you can drive her around here at home. But not to go and meet the other packs,” he insisted.

“Fine.”

The next morning we loaded into the cars. Matilda had given each car a snack pack for the first day. We would spend the better part of two days driving to a remote part of Canada. We had planned out rest stops and food stops, but since we could switch drivers, we wouldn’t need to stop for sleep. Finlay took the first pass at driving and it was nice being just the two of us.

“How do you really feel about seeing your brother?” I asked once we had got out on the highway and relaxed. Finlay had taken my hand and I knew this was the best time to have this conversation. He tried to shrug it off.

“I have met him once a year in the joint pack meetings,” he said.

“And it has never gone well. Each year he has tried something new to force us into his pack,” I reminded him.

“Yeah. I don’t see that changing,” Finlay admitted.

“Have you figured out why?”

“Pride, probably. He doesn’t want to look weak in front of the other packs. And I think they have realised that a pack made up mostly of warriors and top tiers is no fun as they now need to do everything.” I hummed. If the pack’s warriors were led to believe they were bigger and better than everyone else, there would be trouble when you asked that warrior to start cleaning toilets or cook for the pack. Which is why that kind of mindset always makes the pack fragile.

“I guess they would have a hard time recruiting new members that aren’t warriors if word got out how they are being treated,” I thought out loud.

“That is my guess as well,” Finlay agreed.

“So? You haven’t answered my first question,” I insisted.

“I don’t like it. I hate that he tries to manipulate me using our mother and I hate the constant need to prove our pack is not an extension of his,” he told me. I placed my other hand on top of his, sandwiching it between both of mine.

“This time you won’t be alone. We will deal with it,” I told him. He glanced over at me and smiled.

A couple of hours later we stopped at a rest stop and stretched our legs, used the bathroom, ate and switched drivers.

“Are you sure you can handle it?” Finlay asked for the third time as he got into the passenger seat.

“It’s a car, not a spaceship. I think I will figure it out,” I said confidently as I adjusted the seat.

“Fine. Just ask if you need to know something.”

“You are right next to me. It will be fine,” I assured him as I drove off. The biggest difference from my car was that the truck was an automatic shift. It took a little while to adjust to not having to change manually.

Slowly but surely, we made our way towards the destination. The small caravan of cars had a surprisingly easy time sticking together and only twice did we need to wait for someone to catch up.

“It will be nice to sleep in a bed tonight,” Finlay remarked as we got close to the area the games were held in. The council owned a large piece of land in the middle of the Canadian wild. There were no humans for miles and it made it the ideal place to hold the games as well as any joint pack meetings.

“Yes, I’m looking forward to stretching out on a bed,” I agreed. Sleeping in the car was not a comfortable experience when you really couldn’t adjust the seat too much due to all the luggage we had in the back.

“Want company on that bed?” Finlay asked and wiggled his eyebrows. I laughed and punched him in his shoulder.

“In your dreams,” I said.

“Quite often,” he admitted.

“Perv.” We both laughed. On the council grounds there were cabins packs could rent for the month of the games. If you didn’t want to rent one, or couldn’t afford to do so, there were areas for camping. The top five packs got bigger cabins, free

of charge. Those cabins had, in addition to the bedrooms, kitchen and living area all cabins had, a gym and a conference room. For all other packs there were joint gyms that could be booked if you wanted private access and also joint conference rooms. We had booked a cabin years ago. It was just a more comfortable option that would give us advantages. We had made sure to budget for the rent. We had also booked private gym times well in advance. The last couple of hours had been spent driving on a small gravel road in the middle of a deep forest. Seemingly out of nowhere there was a checkpoint. One of the warriors manning it stepped forward to check who we were.

“Welcome Alpha Finlay. You have cabin twenty-five. If you scan this QR code it gives you access to a map of the area and the schedule. The opening of the games is in two days’ time,” the warrior said. Finlay took out his phone and scanned the code the warrior held up.

“Thank you,” he said. The gate was raised and we drove through. Finlay handed me his phone, and I guided him to our cabin. The cabins were spread out over a large area in a forested part of the land. It gave the feeling of privacy, as you couldn’t directly see another cabin. The cabin we had been given was nice. It was a large log cabin with ten bedrooms divided on the top two floors, a kitchen and a living room on the bottom floor. It had already been decided the participants in the games would each get a bedroom on the third floor and the supporting staff would pair up two to each room on the second floor. We decided to spend the rest of the day unpacking and get set up. We went to bed early, as we all felt the need for a good night’s sleep before facing the other packs the next day.

Chapter 30



Amie

I woke up the next morning and took a moment to prepare myself mentally for the day. For each day we spent here the chance of me running into someone from my old pack increased. I got up and got dressed in a pair of jeans and a tank top, me, Finlay, and Sam would be doing a lot of walking around. It made sense to dress comfortably in the summer heat. As I was about to exit my room there was a soft knock on the door. I opened it and saw Finlay standing outside.

"Morning, Red," he said and took half a step toward me.

"Morning, Finn," I said with a smile.

"Ready for today?" he asked.

"As ready as I'm going to get. How about you?" He took my hand and placed a kiss on my palm.

"I'm ready," he said. We went downstairs together and all of us sat down to have breakfast. We went through what the goal for everyone was for the day and then we set off.

"I'm heading over to the gym to make sure our bookings are secured," Sam told me and Finlay.

"Good. Me and Amie will go over to the council building and make sure they have registered us and look if any of our allies have arrived," Finlay said. As we walked toward the official building, I tried to take in as much of the surroundings as I could. We would be here for a month, the sooner I got used to the place, the better. Most of the land was covered in forest. It was the old type of forest with tall trees and minimal undergrowth. It gave the place a feeling of being a large building with a roof and tall pillars. It was perfect for what we needed it to be. The area with the cabins had younger trees that acted as privacy fences between the cabins and the same was true for the campgrounds. The gyms, public kitchen and bathrooms were all located between the living areas and the council building. I was just going to tell Finlay that the way the grounds were organised would make it easy to navigate when I caught the scent of someone familiar. I stopped and looked around.

"Amie?" Finlay asked. For once, I ignored him as I turned towards where the scent came from. About twenty feet away, I saw my brother. He was looking at me like he couldn't believe his eyes. I smiled at him, hoping he would be happy to see me. Elder covered the distance between us in seconds and drew me into a tight embrace.

"Armeria," he said and tightened the embrace.

"Hi, Elder," I said and returned the hug. I felt Finlay standing just behind me. Close enough to intervene if there was an issue, but not so close as to intrude on the moment. After a moment, Elder took a step back and held me at arm's length so he could look at me. He had got older, he didn't look as carefree as he used to. But then he was a Beta now. I understood the weight of the title.

"Amie, where on earth have you been?" he asked with a boyish smile. I had to laugh. My worries he would be mad at me all melted away.

"A little here and there, but mostly at the Blue Mountain pack," I said, looking over my shoulder at Finlay. Elder followed my gaze and frowned. I knew what he was going to say. "I asked him not to tell you. I wasn't ready," I explained. Elder looked back at me and nodded. His smile returned.

"It is good to see you. You are all grown up. You look good, little sister."

"Thank you. So do you. The Beta title suits you," I told him.

"I have a lot of things to tell you, and a lot of questions about your life as well," he said. That is when I noticed the mark on his neck and I grinned.

"I see you have found someone who can stand to be mated to you," I teased him. It was natural to fall back into how I had always talked to him. He gave me a brilliant smile.

"I have. I found my true mate a couple of years back, Becky. She is perfect. Both mom and dad adore her. And, you are an aunt. We had a son almost a year ago. Armino is back home with mom and dad, but Becky is here. I can't wait for you

to meet her," he excitedly told me. I smiled at him, he sounded happy and I loved it.

"Congratulations, big brother. I'm so happy for you. I can't wait to meet your mate. I have some good stories about you she needs to hear," I told him. He laughed and tried to ruffle my hair. After years of avoiding the same move from Finlay, I easily dodged his hand. He continued to laugh and pulled me into another hug.

"I really have missed you, little sister. Dad and I wanted to find you, but mom forbade us. She said you would let us know when you were ready," he said in a serious voice. I sent a silent thank you to my mother.

"She was right. I needed time," I told him.

"I'm sorry you thought this was the only way forward. I wished I could have been there for you," he said.

"Don't blame yourself, Elder. You were a good older brother, the best I could have wished for. It wasn't your fault, it was just what needed to be done. I'm happy, I have a good life and I'm in a good pack," I told him. We let go of each other and took a step back. Elder reached for my hand as if he needed to have physical contact to make sure I didn't vanish.

"Mom and dad will be so happy. You are okay with me telling them, right?" he asked.

"Of course. I would never ask you to keep it a secret."

“Will you give me your phone number so I can give it to them? They will want to call you,” he told me. I smiled and nodded. He added my number to his phone. Elder turned his attention to Finlay. Finlay had stood quiet during my reunion with his brother.

“Thank you for accepting my sister into your pack and looking after her, Alpha Finlay,” Elder said and inclined his head.

“It was my pleasure. I couldn’t ask for a better Beta,” Finlay said. Elder’s eyes snapped back to me.

“Beta?” he asked.

“Dad rubbed off on me too,” I told him. He was about to ask me something when both him and me scented another familiar wolf. He gave me a worried look. I should have reassured him, but I was too shocked to do anything. My eyes went from my brother to his Alpha, standing a few feet behind him. James had also changed. But it wasn’t the fact he looked older and more mature that had my heart pumping like crazy. It was the fact I still felt the mate bond between us. I stepped backwards, away from my brother. I instinctively sought out my safe place. Finlay read my body language and he took two quick strides and placed himself between me and both my brother and James. I was confused. Why was the bond still there? Was the moon goddess so cruel that she had given me James as my second chance mate? No. That wasn’t it. I took a deep breath and tried to clear my mind. The bond was there, but it felt weak, like a rope that had been rubbing against rocks.

“Amie,” James said in a voice I couldn’t read. He took a step towards me. I took a step backwards and Finlay let out a low growl as a warning.

“Okay. Let’s calm down,” Elder said. Looking between his Alpha and me.

‘Are you okay?’ Finlay asked me in a mindlink.

‘No. I don’t know what is happening, Finlay. I-I can still feel the mate bond,’ I told him. He stiffened and then looked over his shoulder at me.

“Amie, you are still my mate,” James said.

“What?!” Elder exclaimed and looked at me. “That can’t be. I saw the rejection myself,” he added. I nodded.

“I can feel the bond as well,” I confirmed. “But it’s faint.”

“Alpha Finlay, step aside,” James told Finlay.

“No. I don’t care what bond you have with Amie. She is part of my pack and under my protection. She clearly isn’t comfortable around you so I’m not going to step aside,” he said. I felt myself relax a little. I was still safe.

“This is a mess. What do we do now?” Elder asked.

“We need to talk to the council. They may know what is happening, and they will guide us on what to do,” Finlay said. James and Elder both nodded. Finlay turned to me and I nodded. He put a hand on my back to guide me towards the council building.

‘I swear he rejected me,’ I mindlinked Finlay as all four of us walked together. Finlay made sure to keep himself in between me and the other two. I was afraid

Finlay would think I had made up my story.

'I know, Amie. Something isn't right about all of this. But I believe you,' he told me. I relaxed a little more.

Chapter 31



Finlay

We all walked into the council building together. I made sure to keep Amie separated from the other two. Her reunion with her brother had gone better than expected and I was happy for her. It wasn't hard to see how much her brother adored his sister. But something was off. This mate bond thing felt off. I had seen the way Alpha James had looked at Amie, like a wish come true. I was not ready to let her go. In my mind and my heart, Amie was mine. By her reaction to all of this, I would say she wasn't thrilled either. I had never seen her back away from anything before. With my hand on her back to make sure she knew I was there, I walked straight up to the desk where a clerk sat.

"We need an emergency meeting with the council," I told him. The wolf behind the desk was about to say something as he looked up. He met my eyes and then looked over to Alpha James. He seemed to change his mind about what he was about to tell us.

"Yes, there seem to be some upset feelings. May I have your names and packs and I will tell the council." We gave him what he asked for and he asked us to wait for

one moment. He directed us to wait in separate areas. I was grateful for his tact, as it gave me a chance to make sure Amie was okay.

'Are you okay to do this? Should I ask Sam to come and take you to the cabin?' I asked her in a mindlink. She gave me a shaky smile.

'No. I'll be fine. I need to do this, I need the answers,' she replied. She seemed to hesitate for a moment. Then she took my hand. I gave her hand a squeeze to let her know I understood, and then I let her be with her thoughts. She would let me know if she needed me. I had my back towards Alpha James and made sure to block his view of Amie.

"Please follow me," the clerk said and showed us into the council room. The council members sat around the conference table and we stood at the end of it.

"Alpha Finlay, Alpha James, we were told you needed to speak with us, the head councilman said.

"We do. We need your help with understanding a situation," I said. "My Beta will explain." Amie took a deep breath and explained the situation to the council.

"The bond is still there," she ended her explanation. "I don't understand why." The council members looked at each other.

"Is this a true description of the situation, Alpha James?" one of them asked. Alpha James glanced at Amie. He must know the story showed him in a bad light.

"It is," he admitted.

“And when you rejected Beta Amie, did you perform the rejection in the correct way?” Another council member asked.

“The correct way?” Alpha James asked. There was a communal sigh from the council.

“This is what happens when the packs are afraid of educating their members about rejections because they think it will put ideas into their heads,” a woman complained.

“Yes. If someone is going to reject their mate, they will do it. But if they aren’t taught the proper way, this happens,” another agreed.

“For a rejection to be completed, the one rejecting has to first initiate the rejection, then the one being rejected has to accept the rejection. If this isn’t done, the mate bond will remain. As it has been activated but hasn’t been accepted, it will not be in full force. And, as you both have noticed, it will deteriorate as it’s not being maintained. But it will not go away on its own and neither of the parties will be able to gain a second chance mate,” the head councilman explained.

“So all I have to do is to accept the rejection? Or do we need to start all over again?” Amie asked.

“No, you can just accept it and it will be completed. But, I will remind you that if you do so, both of you will have to sit this year’s games out. Even if the bond between you is weak, it is still a bond and the rules are clear about newly rejected wolves,” the councilman reminded us. I cursed internally. We hadn’t counted on this happening and hadn’t brought a stand in. We could use one of the support staff even if none of them was half as good as Amie.

‘It’s okay, Amie. Accept the rejection, and we will figure it out,’ I mindlinked her. I hated the idea she would have to live with a bond she didn’t want.

‘No, Finn, the needs of the pack come first. If we place low in the games it means another ten years of living in fear of what will happen. Another ten years of possible attacks and the possibility of losing more pack members. I won’t be responsible for that,’ she told me.

‘Amie, there is a possibility of attacks even if we place high,’ I reminded her. She gave me one of her looks and it secretly made me happy as it showed she was coming back to her usual self.

‘We both know the risk is much lower if you are high ranking,’ she pointed out. It was true, I had no good argument to come back with.

“If I don’t accept the rejection now, when can I do it without causing issues with the games?” she asked the council.

“As soon as the final game has ended,” one of the council members said.

“I guess you aren’t keen on sitting this one out either?” Amie asked Alpha James. He frowned.

“No,” he agreed. She nodded and took a deep breath in. Amie walked around me before I could object and looked Alpha James dead in the eyes.

“Let’s make a deal. I won’t accept your rejection until after the final game. In return you agree that neither one of us has a claim to the other and are free to continue our lives as if the bond does not exist. Deal?” she asked him and reached

out her hand. He looked at her for a long moment. I was almost convinced he would turn the deal down.

"Deal," he finally said and shook her hand. His eyes grew bigger as their hands met. When Amie let go of his hand she discreetly rubbed hers against her pants.

"Well then. If that was all. Please make sure to educate your packs so we can avoid this in the future," The head councilman said. I bowed at the council, as did the others and we walked out of the room. I wanted to take Amie straight back to the cabin so I could talk to her, make sure she was alright. But she stopped outside the building to say goodbye to her brother and make sure he knew she still wanted to meet his mate.

"Amie, why on earth are you participating in the games?" Alpha James asked. The tone of his voice had both me and my wolf on high alert. I would have growled at him again if Amie hadn't placed her hand on my arm.

"Why on earth wouldn't I?" she asked with almost as much sharpness in her voice. Her brother looked between his sister and his Alpha.

"Amie, I think James is just worried. The games are relentless, and for someone without a wolf, they can be deadly," her brother said. Both Amie and I looked at him like he was an idiot. Then it dawned on both of us that neither her brother nor Alpha James knew about Amie's wolf. I felt a grin take over my face. Amie smiled at her brother.

"I would agree. But I have a wolf, so that won't be an issue," she told them and I enjoyed the look on both their faces, especially Alpha James.

"Amie's wolf is a tough one, large, fast and stealthy," I said, just to rub some salt in the wounds.

"You have a wolf?" her brother asked.

"I do. She came to me after Finlay offered me a place in his pack. I guess she felt it was the right fit for her, and for me," Amie said. "I think we need to get going. This morning has not gone as planned and we have some catching up to do. You have my number, please let me know when you are ready to introduce your mate," she then said and then she looked at me.

"Alpha James, Beta Elder," I said and nodded to them. I then placed my hand on Amie's back to lead her towards the cabin. We had only walked a couple of steps when Alpha James called to Amie.

"Amie, one moment. Can we have a talk? There are things we need to sort out," he said as he walked up to us.

"No, James. I don't think so. We agreed this mate bond would not affect things between us. We have lived with it for ten years. Another month shouldn't make a difference," she told him and turned her back on him.

Chapter 32



Amie

As Finlay took me back to the cabin, my world settled around me. We didn't speak on the way back, or when he sat me down on a chair on the sundeck at the back of the cabin. I heard him telling his aunt there had been a change of plans and we would be spending the rest of the morning at the cabin. As usual, Matilda didn't ask why. She just sent him back to me with a tray loaded with tea and cookies. I smiled as he put it down next to me. Instead of sitting down on the chair on the other side of the small table, he sat down on the ottoman in front of me.

"This doesn't change anything," he told me as he put a tea mug in my hands.

"Doesn't it?" I asked.

"No, Amie, it doesn't. Unless you are thinking of honouring the mate bond." I looked at him like he had lost his mind and he chuckled. "I take that as a no," he said.

"That is a definitive no. Why would I accept a mate bond with someone who doesn't want me? Despite everything, James and I were friends and I wouldn't force a bond on him," I told him. Finlay smiled and placed his hand on my cheek. I leaned into his touch.

"You were in too much of a shock to see it. But Alpha James isn't as unaffected by you as you think. And now that he knows you have a wolf. I'm predicting we will be seeing quite a lot of the Alpha during our four weeks here," Finlay told me. I made a face.

"I don't care. If he didn't want me at my lowest, I'm not going to consider him at my highest. And, if we put all of that to the side, I don't love him. There is this other man who never looked down on me and who I know will be there for both the good and the bad. That is sexy," I told him.

"Tell me where I can find this man and I will challenge him," Finlay said. I could see the humour in his eyes. I laughed at him and he joined me. Then I sighed.

"This was not supposed to happen. You were the one to find your mate and I was supposed to pretend to be happy for you," I told him. He huffed and his hand on my cheek shifted to the back of my head. For a moment, I thought he was going to kiss me. Instead, he tilted our heads so we leaned our foreheads together.

"Not going to happen. Part of me wish you were more selfish and would have accepted the rejection already. But then that wouldn't be you, Red. I have already submitted to waiting until this is over until I stake my claim on your feelings. I can be patient. But it doesn't mean I will be passive. I'm not going to sit and watch another Alpha take what I see as mine," he told me.

"I should have just let you mark me on my birthday," I told him. He chuckled and placed a kiss on my forehead before sitting back up.

"No, Red. You did the right thing. We needed to talk before taking that step and to be honest, if you hadn't stopped us, that is where we would have ended up," he said. "I mean it when I say you are worth the wait. When we take the step, it will be because we want to spend the rest of our life together."

"You are just too good to be true, Finn. Thank you for believing in me," I honestly told him.

"After six years, I know you, Amie. Will you be okay? You have had a lot of emotional things thrown at you today, and I think you will get a call from your parents any minute." At the mention of my parents I had to smile.

"I'm looking forward to the call. And I'm okay. Give me an hour and a call with my parents and I will be back to my old self," I told him. I then hesitated.

"What?" he asked.

"Nothing. You should get back out there. Our morning have been overturned because of me."

"Red," he said in the voice he used when he meant business.

"I was going to ask if you would stay for my call with my parents. I'm looking forward to it, but I'm also nervous and you always keep me calm. But you have things to do. I will be okay," I told him. He smiled at me.

"You think I was going to head back out before we have finished the cookies my aunt sent me here with? Dream on. I'm going to sit here and eat cookies and we are going to plan what to do for the opening day tomorrow," Finlay told me. I smiled at him.

"I guess I can share the cookies," I told him and gave him one.